Preston R. Johnston

PhD Candidate
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Education

Massachusetts Institute of Technology, 2021 – present (*expected May 2027*)
Ph.D. Candidate, Political Science
Fields: Political Economy, Quantitative Methods
Committee: Kathleen Thelen (chair), Devin Caughey, Evan Lieberman, Leah Stokes (UCSB)

Princeton University, 2017 – 2021
A.B. in Politics, *magna cum laude*
Minor in Statistics and Machine Learning

Other affiliations

Harvard University Minda de Gunzburg Center for European Studies. Graduate student affiliate. 2025 – present.

Research interests

American political economy; comparative political economy; environmental and climate politics; climate adaptation; property insurance; money in politics; causal inference

Publications

* *indicates dissertation paper*

1. **Voters Uncovered: Home Insurance and the Electoral Effects of Climate Costs***
   Forthcoming at the Journal of Political Institutions and Political Economy

Working papers

1. **When the Rich Confront Risk: Climate Change and the Politics of Home Insurance*** (*Job market paper*)
2. **Ethnicity and Climate Attitudes in Africa** (with Evan Lieberman and Devin Caughey). *Under review.*

Work in progress

1. **The Role of Business in Democratic Backsliding in the United States** (with Kathleen Thelen and Alex Hertel-Fernandez)
2. **The Distributive Politics of Climate Risk Information: Evidence from Oregon** (with Janet Malzahn, Brice Green, Andy McEvoy, and Chris Dunn)
3. **Swimming in the Flood? Ideology and Individual-Level Climate Adaptation in Brazil** (with Clemente T. Sanchez)

4. **The Politics of Reinsurance Pools in the UK and Australia***

5. **Pulling the Fire Alarm? Insurer Corporate Behavior Under Climate Change**

Presentations and conferences

Organizer:

- Stanford Workshop on Climate Risk, Resilience, and Insurance. *Co-organized with Newsha Ajami (Stanford), Bruce Cain (Stanford), and Doug Leonard (Stanford).* June 2026.
- Yale-MIT graduate student workshop on climate and insurance. *Co-organized with Eric Scheuch (Yale).* April 2026.

Invited as presenter:

- Northeast Climate Policy Workshop. October 2026 at Brown University.
- Workshop on Business Power and Politics. October 2026 at Northwestern University.
- Guarding the Guardrails of Democracy Workshop. October 2026 at Harvard Kennedy School.
- American Political Science Association (**APSA**). September 2026 in Boston, MA.
- Political Economy of Climate and the Environment (**PECE**). September 2026 in Cambridge, MA.
- Consortium on the American Political Economy (**CAPE**) Summer Research Conference. July 2026.
- Consortium on the American Political Economy (**CAPE**) Summer Academy. May-June 2026 at UC Berkeley.
- Copenhagen Business School - Princeton Money in Politics Conference. June 2026 in Copenhagen, Denmark.
- The New Political Economy of Welfare Systems in Times of Climate Change. June 2026 at Sciences Po in Paris, France.
- Climate Pipeline Conference. May 2026 at Columbia University.
- Political Institutions and Political Economy collaborative (**PIPE**). December 2025 at the University of Southern California.
- American Political Science Association (**APSA)**. September 2025 in Vancouver, BC, Canada.
- Political Economy and Welfare Research Network Early Career Workshop. June 2025 at Temple University.
- MIT Center for International Studies Global Climate Adaptation Workshop. April 2025.
- American Political Science Association (**APSA**). September 2024 in Philadelphia, PA.
- Midwest Political Science Association (**MPSA**). April 2024 in Chicago, IL.
- Working Group in African Political Economy (**WGAPE**). March 2024 in Accra, Ghana.

Invited as discussant:

- Council for European Studies (**CES**) International Conference of Europeanists. June 2025 in Philadelphia, PA. Invited discussant for panel titled "The Green Firm."

- Seminar on State and Capitalism Since 1800. December 2024 at Harvard University Center for European Studies. Invited discussant for Charnysh et al., "Place Not Race: Identities, Social Proximity and the Global Climate Emergency."

Teaching

MIT:

Teaching Assistant (TA) positions:

- Introduction to American Politics (undergraduate), Professor Devin Caughey. Fall 2024.
- Quantitative Research Methods II: Causal Inference (graduate), Professor F. Daniel Hidalgo. Spring 2025.
- Taught three class sessions for Democracy, Development, and Climate Change in Africa (undergraduate), Professor Evan Lieberman. Spring 2026.

Workshops and miscellaneous:

- Global Diversity Lab Pathways Program: "How to read a quantitative social science paper." Summer 2024, Summer 2025.

Grants and awards

- MIT CIS PhD Student Summer Research Grant ($5,000) for fieldwork in Australia. 2025.
- MIT CIS Student Working Group Grants ($1,500). 2024 - 2026.
- MIT Walter A. Rosenblith Presidential Fellow. 2021-2023.
- National finalist, United States Universities Debating Championship. 2020.

Research experience

- Kathleen Thelen (MIT) and Alex Hertel-Fernandez (Columbia). 2025 - present.
- Evan Lieberman (MIT). 2022 - 2025.
- Chenzi Xu (Stanford economics). 2020 - 2021.
- Leonard Wantchekon (Princeton). 2021.
- Matias Iaryczower (Princeton). 2019 - 2020.

Service

- Co-organizer, MIT Comparative Politics and Political Economy (COPE) workshop. *Co-organized with Clemente T. Sanchez (MIT)*. 2024 - present.
- MIT Graduate Student Council department social chair. 2022 - 2024.
- Reviewer for: *American Journal of Political Science*, *Socio-Economic Review*

References

Kathleen Thelen
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Devin Caughey
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Evan Lieberman
evanlieb@mit.edu